# Epilogue

***an overview of Einstein's legacy,***
***past and future,***
***and an update on several central characters***

It now is nearly a full century since Einstein destroyed Newton's concept of space and time as absolute, and began laying the foundations for his own legacy. Over the intervening century, Einstein's legacy has grown to include, among many other things, a warpage of spacetime and a set of exotic objects made wholly and solely from that warpage: black holes, gravitational waves, singularities (clothed and naked), wormholes, and time machines.

At one epoch in history or another, physicists have regarded each of these objects as outrageous.

- We have met, in this book, Eddington's, Wheeler's, and even Einstein's vigorous skepticism about *black holes;* Eddington and Einstein died before they were firmly proved wrong, but Wheeler became a convert and black-hole advocate.
- During the 1940s and 1950s, a number of physicists, building on mistaken interpretations of the general relativistic mathematics they were studying, were highly skeptical of *gravitational waves* (ripples of curvature)—but that is a story for another book, and the skepticism long since has vanished.
- It was a horrendous shock to most physicists, and still is to many, to discover that singularities are an inevitable consequence of Einstein's general relativistic laws. Some physicists derive comfort from faith in Penrose's cosmic censorship conjecture (that all